

Chapter 11**OUR VALUES, OUR BEHAVIOR****Learning Outcomes**

By the end of this chapter students will be able to:

1. Recognize that there are different values.
2. Identify the factors that influence values (culture, education, religion, etc).
3. Describe their personal values and how they developed these values.
4. Identify values from given scenarios.
5. Recognize the values underpinning their behavior.
6. Understand that responses to a given situation may differ because of different values.

WHAT ARE VALUES?

Values are the principles that guide the way we live our lives. Some examples of values are punctuality, honesty, fairness, collaboration and competitiveness. We may have values which are particular to us. Values can be related to our personality such as our desire to work with others. Values can also be related to our needs to be safe or to do well in school so as to get a good job. They can also be related to our understanding of our social context such as the value of cleanliness or care for the environment.

Our values develop from a combination of our background, our experiences, and our developing sense of self. While some of these values may stay the same throughout our lives such as the desire to work independently, others will develop and change as we do. For example, it is very common for people to change their attitudes to salary, job security, and working hours as they change from being single to getting married and becoming a parent.

While we have our own values, we also share some of the values of the people around us such as our family or friends, or our ethnic or national group. For example, we may share the values of love of family and loyalty to friends as well as the values of respect for elders or hospitality.

Values are ideals. Life in the real world often requires us to make choices and compromises, and we constantly prioritize our values accordingly. We may change them through experience or pressure. For example, you usually break the line because you want to get to the canteen first. One day someone else breaks the line and gets in front of you. You realize that breaking the line is unfair. From the next day you wait in line for your turn.

Activity

List three values you think all the members of your family share and list three values that think you and your friends have in common.

Factors that Influence the Development of Our Values

Family

Our families have the most influence on our lives. They are the ones responsible for teaching us the difference between right and wrong. From the moment that we are born, they become our role model. What happens at home shapes our values. For example, if at home we are taught to respect others, then we will respect others. If conflicts at home are solved by arguing and fighting with each other, then we might think it is alright to solve conflicts by arguing and fighting.

School

Schools also influence the development of our values. Schools require us to come on time, be neat and clean, wait for our turn and do our work well. Through these requirements they teach us the values of punctuality, cleanliness, respect for others and hard work. In class if our teachers encourage us to work with others, we learn to value collaboration but if they teach us to compete with each other we learn to value competition.



Personal Values

Friends

As we grow up our friends influence our values. Friends can have a positive or a negative influence on the development of our values. If our friends study hard and are determined to do well in school, we will most probably also study hard so as to do well at school. If our friends bully some children, we may think it is alright to bully others.

Religion

Religion plays a very important role in value development. All religions have codes of behavior for those who follow them and which influence how they live. Very often the laws and social customs in a society are based on religious teachings. Since these laws govern almost all of our day to day behavior, we are influenced by religion in nearly everything we do.

Society

The society in which we live also influences our values. It teaches us what is good and bad and what is desirable and undesirable. Often whatever the society accepts as right, people think of it as right even though sometimes it is wrong. For example, in our society we deal with conflict by using violence. We fight, we burn private and public property and we even kill others. This is wrong. We need to learn how to manage and resolve conflict peacefully.

Media

The media also plays an important role in shaping our values. When we watch television dramas, listen to music, or follow sports activities we begin to develop a liking for some actors, singers or sports people. With time we want to be like them and tend to copy what they do. For example, we may learn from sports people to play fairly or we may learn it is alright to cheat to win.

Activity:

- i) From the list of values given in the box, identify seven (7) values that are important to you. For each of the values chosen, identify who has influenced the development of this value in your life: your family, school, friends, religion society or media. You may indicate more than one.

Achievement (results brought about by making an effort), Care for the environment, Cleanliness, Education (going to school/ college to learn), Fairness (treating others fairly), Family, Forgiveness (to pardon or treat others with mercy), Health (to keep well in mind and body), Honesty (to be sincere and truthful), Perseverance (keep doing a task until successful) Respect for others.

- ii) Who has had the most influence on the values you choose? Why?
- iii) Whose advice do you follow the most: parent, teachers, friends? Why?

Influence of Values on Our Behaviors

Our values have a major influence on our behavior. People who value tradition are more likely to observe their traditions and customs. People for whom time is a value are more likely to complete their work on time and be on time for various functions.

Our behaviors, however, are not always in line with our values. We might value helping others, but fail to do anything when we see someone being bullied. Similarly, we may value the environment but support cutting down trees to widen a road. Why is this so? In the first example, we may feel powerless to help the person being bullied. In the second example, we may feel that a better transportation system will lead to economic growth which is more important than the environment.

This clearly shows that there are various personal reasons as well as societal reasons that prevent us from behaving in accordance with the values we hold. Our families, our education, our culture or the media may also prevent us from behaving according to the values we hold.

SUMMARY

In this chapter we have learnt that values are the principles or standards which guide the way we live our lives and that our values are influenced by our families, school, friends, religion, media and the society in which we live. We have also learnt that values influence our behavior, but that sometimes personal or social pressures prevent us from behaving in accordance with the our values.

EXERCISE

A. Answer the following questions

1. What are the factors that influence our values. Give examples to show how family and school influence our values.
2. List 5 values important to you. For one of the values listed, identify three behaviors you engage in that show this value.
3. Fairness is giving people what they need when they need it. That means playing by the rules, taking turns, sharing, and giving everybody a fair chance. Read each statement. Write fair or not fair for each statement. Rewrite the statements identified as not fair to make them fair,
 - a. Everyone passes the football around but not to the weakest player on your football team.
 - b. You allow someone to cut in line in front of you.
 - c. You wash the dishes and your brother or sister dries them.
 - d. Your brother shares his toys with you and then you make him pick them up all by himself.

- e. You change the rules in the middle of the game because your team is losing.
- f. You find some money in class; you ask whose it is and give it to him/her.
- g. You can't find your pencil and your classmate has an extra one that looks just like yours, so you take

4. Read the scenario below.

Saleem is very good at cricket and knows it. But he makes all the other children in the cricket club feel bad by making negative comments about how they play. When the children vote for Ali instead of him as captain, Saleem is upset. He asks the teacher, "I am the best at cricket, why didn't they vote for me?" The teacher explains that even though he thinks he is helping the other players, he is not showing respect for their feelings. She asks him to ask himself, "Is this how I want someone to talk to me?"

Read each statement below. Write respectful or disrespectful for each statement.

Can't you figure out how to hold the bat?

Would you like my help? I can show you a good way to hold the bat.

What's taking you so long to hit the ball?

That's the dumbest move I ever saw.

Maybe I can show you how to help your partner.

Would you mind if I made a suggestion?

Can't you remember anything I teach you?

B. Make a table

Make a table to show three values you have learnt in school. For each value identify three behaviors you engage in to show that value.

C. Practical work

Identify the ways you can show the value of 'care for the environment'. Demonstrate your value by doing something to show you care for the environment.

D. Extension activity

The world would be different if people did not have values. If people did not have values, what differences do you think would be visible in our day-to-day lives?